

THE BIG CHEESE
Telugu film star Allu Arjun in *Pushpa: The Rise - Part 1*



"THE WORLD OF HINDI FILMMAKERS CENTRES AROUND ANDHERI AND BANDRA. THEY WATCH ENGLISH FILMS AND NETFLIX AND THINK THAT'S MOVIEMAKING. IT ISN'T"

MANISH SHAH
Director & Chairman, Goldmines Telefilms

Manish Shah, director and chairman of Goldmines Telefilms, a production house, knew he had an ace up his sleeve when he acquired the Hindi rights—satellite, digital and theatrical—to Telugu film *Pushpa: The Rise - Part 1*. The seeds of *Pushpa's* success, he says, were sown seven years ago. The Mumbai-based producer had noticed how the Hindi-dubbed versions of Tamil and Telugu films were doing well on TV channels like Star Gold and Sony Max. He also noticed the growing popularity of Allu Arjun on digital—it was evident on Goldmines Films' YouTube channel, where the Telugu star's films had cumulatively amassed 1.2 billion views. The theatrical success of *Pushpa's* Hindi-dubbed version—which has entered the Rs 100 crore club—was inevitable.

Shah, who has been acquiring 'South films' for satellite release for 14 years now, also attributes *Pushpa's* pan-India success in part to Hindi cinema's failure to entertain audiences. "*Mass action film hum Hindi mein bana hi nahin rahe* [we just aren't making mass action films in Hindi]," he bemoans. One Rohit Shetty film isn't enough, he says, and Salman Khan's films lack "content". "Action is not simply about having a hero beat 10 people up. It needs to be entertaining, have good dialogue and songs." Tamil and Telugu filmmakers offer "more action and scale", while Hindi filmmakers, he feels, are alienating audiences outside the metros. "Hindi film directors stay between Andheri and Bandra [suburbs in Mumbai] and for them the world revolves around these areas," he quips. "They have grown up watching English films and Netflix and they think that is moviemaking. That's not so."

With cinema halls in Maharashtra, a key market, shut for six months in 2021, producers in Mumbai either chose to hold their films' release or took the OTT route. The *Ormax Box Office Report 2020-21* recorded cumulative revenue across 2020 and 2021 down to Rs 5,757 crore, from Rs 11,000 crore in 2019 alone. Meanwhile, cinemas in Tamil Nadu, Telangana and Andhra Pradesh were closed for a shorter period and 2021 saw a steady supply of films. As a result, Telugu and Tamil films grossed an estimated Rs 1,300 crore and Rs 700 crore annually, respectively, and had a 29 per cent and 17 per cent share of the box office, respectively, in 2020-2021, compared to Hindi cinema, whose share declined from 44 per cent to 27 per cent. "The cumulative share of the four southern film industries went up from 36 per cent in 2019 to 59 per cent in 2020 and 2021, highlighting how they managed to navigate the pandemic with relatively more success than Hindi films," says Gautam Jain, partner, Ormax Media.

The new year is unlikely to be a cakewalk for Hindi films either. S.S. Rajamouli's magnum opus *RRR*, part two of